up the first launch ground system, comprising of telemetry, tele-command, and radar. He also chalked out a detailed work plan with SHAR for the flight trials. Dr Sundararajan closely monitored mission objectives and concurrently updated the systems. Dr Srinivasan, a competent launch vehicle designer, discharged al my complementary and supplementary functions as the SLV deputy project director. He noticed what I had overlooked, heard the points I failed to listen to, and suggested possibilities that I had not so much as visualized.

We learned the hard way that the biggest problem of project management is to achieve a regular and efficient interfacing between the different individuals and work centres. Hard work can be set at nought in the absence of proper coordination.

I had the fortune of having YS Rajan from the ISRO headquarters as my friend in those times. Rajan was (and is) a universal friend. His friendship embraced with equal warmth turners, fitters, electricians and drivers as wel as scientists, engineers, contractors and bureaucrats. Today when the press cal s me a ‘welder of people’, I attribute this to Rajan. His close interaction with different work centres